

1 The history of video game consoles

The recent economic recession has taken its toll on every single industry in the world, and up until recently, only the video game industry seemed to have bucked the trend. While JP Morgan downed its shutters and people scattered helter-skelter looking for jobs, game console manufacturers were sitting pretty with some high sales numbers.

Understanding what makes them tick requires a fair knowledge of the history of this 37-year-old industry (yes, thirty-seven!). Fortunately, your good friends here at Digit have never shied away from flexing unnecessary knowledge about irrelevant geeky facts.

The first video game console for home usage was the Magnavox Odyssey, was released on May 24, 1972. However, as far as the public at large is concerned, the first 'true console' was Atari's 'Pong', created by founder Nolan Bushnell, who is known as the father of video games. Pong was released for home use in 1975, although its idea was taken from a similar game in the Odyssey.



While Magnavox Odyssey is technically the first console, home video games came into the spotlight with Atari's Pong

The Pong console, at the time, was little more than a motherboard and chip with the single Pong game running on it, with two crude controllers attached to the device. However, little did they know that this was to set up the future of a multi-billion-dollar video games industry.

The next significant step forward for video game consoles came in 1983, with the launch of the Nintendo Entertainment System (NES) in Japan, which was subsequently taken to the US and European markets in 1985 and 1986, respectively.

If the Atari and Pong gave birth to home-based video game consoles, the NES can be credited with making the video game console a part of 'family entertainment'. Video games, which were often seen as something for the kids,